Checklist: Creating a Search Ad Campaign

Use this checklist to plan, build, and quality-check a Google Search campaign. Complete the strategic decisions before opening the campaign builder so the settings, keywords, ad, and landing page all support the same conversion goal.

Business / offer _____

Primary conversion _____

Target audience _____

Location and language _____

Average daily budget _____

1. Define the Campaign Foundation

- ☐ Write one measurable campaign objective, such as completed purchases, qualified lead forms, booked appointments, or phone calls.
- ☐ Choose the primary conversion action that represents success; do not optimize toward a low-value action simply because it is easy to measure.
- ☐ Confirm that website conversion tracking is installed, tested, and recording the correct action before using conversion-focused bidding.
- ☐ Describe the audience's need, urgency, and likely search intent in one or two sentences.
- ☐ Name the specific product, service, offer, or location this campaign will promote.
- ☐ Set a realistic success target: target cost per acquisition, return on ad spend, lead volume, or another business outcome.

2. Choose Campaign Settings

- ☐ Select **Search** as the campaign type and choose the goal that matches the primary conversion.
- ☐ Use a clear campaign name that identifies the offer, geography, audience, and date or version when useful.
- ☐ Choose geographic targets and exclusions deliberately; review whether the location option should emphasize people in the area or people showing interest in it.
- ☐ Choose only the languages the business can support in its ads and landing-page experience.
- ☐ Review Search Partners and Display Network options instead of accepting them without considering the campaign purpose.
- ☐ Set start and end dates, ad schedule, devices, and audience observations when they support the strategy.

3. Build Focused Keyword Groups

Organize keywords into tightly related ad groups so each search theme can receive a specific ad and a closely matched landing page.

- [ ] List the words and phrases a ready-to-act customer would use, not only the terminology the organization uses internally.
- [ ] Separate distinct products, services, needs, locations, or stages of intent into different ad groups.
- [ ] Keep each ad group's keywords close enough in meaning that one focused ad can address all of them naturally.
- [ ] Use Keyword Planner or other evidence to compare search demand, estimated cost, and competition.
- [ ] Choose broad, phrase, or exact match intentionally; understand that match types influence which searches can trigger the ad.
- [ ] Add negative keywords for irrelevant meanings, audiences, locations, jobs, research queries, or products the business does not offer.
- [ ] Check for duplicate or overlapping themes that could make multiple ad groups compete for the same searches.
- [ ] Name every ad group for its single search theme.

KEYWORD GROUP TEST

- Can you describe the group's search intent in one short phrase?
- Would every keyword make sense with the same ad headline and landing page?
- Would a searcher immediately recognize that the ad answers the query?

4. Select Bidding and Budget

- [ ] Match the bid strategy to the goal: clicks for qualified traffic, conversions for actions, or conversion value for revenue or differentiated values.
- [ ] Use conversion-focused automated bidding only when the primary conversion action and its values are accurate.
- [ ] If using Manual CPC, set a defensible default ad-group bid and review whether individual high-value keywords need different maximum CPC bids.
- [ ] If using a target CPA or target ROAS, base the target on business economics and available campaign data rather than an arbitrary number.
- [ ] Set an average daily budget the organization can sustain through the learning period and normal day-to-day spending variation.
- [ ] Estimate whether the budget can generate enough clicks or conversions to evaluate performance.
- [ ] Document the guardrails: maximum acceptable CPC, CPA, monthly spend, and any approval threshold.

5. Create the Responsive Search Ad

Write assets that can work in multiple combinations. The ad should connect the searcher's intent to a specific benefit, credible reason to choose the organization, and clear next action.

- [ ] Enter the final URL for the most relevant landing page, not automatically the home page.
- [ ] Add descriptive display-path text that helps users anticipate the page content.
- [ ] Write at least three headlines and two descriptions; use additional unique assets when they add meaningful message variety.
- [ ] Include an important keyword or close concept naturally in at least one headline.
- [ ] Create distinct headline roles: product or service, customer benefit, differentiator or proof, location when relevant, and call to action.
- [ ] Keep every headline within 30 characters and every description within 90 characters.
- [ ] Make each asset understandable alone and in different combinations; do not create sentences that depend on a fixed order.
- [ ] Use a specific call to action that matches the conversion, such as Book an Appointment, Request a Quote, or Shop the Collection.
- [ ] Verify that every claim, price, promotion, deadline, and location is accurate and supported on the landing page.
- [ ] Pin a headline or description only when content must appear in a specific position; recognize that pinning reduces combination flexibility.
- [ ] Preview the ad on multiple device sizes and review spelling, capitalization, punctuation, and policy warnings.

AD MESSAGE MAP

- Search intent: What is the person trying to find or accomplish?
- Value: What practical benefit does the offer provide?
- Proof: Why should the searcher trust this advertiser?
- Action: What should the person do after clicking?

6. Add Useful Search Ad Assets

- [ ] Add sitelinks that lead to useful secondary pages and give each one meaningful link text.
- [ ] Add callouts, structured snippets, location, call, price, promotion, image, or other assets only when they are accurate and helpful.
- [ ] Confirm that every asset URL works and leads to a page that matches the asset promise.
- [ ] Review whether optional assets could distract from or conflict with the primary conversion.

7. Prepare the Landing Page

The landing page should continue the same promise made by the keyword and ad. A strong click is wasted if visitors cannot quickly confirm that they reached the right place and complete the intended action.

- ☐ Match the page headline, offer, product or service, location, and call to action to the ad group's keywords and ad message.
- ☐ Place the primary value proposition and next action near the top of the page.
- ☐ Make the conversion path obvious: a visible button, short form, clear phone number, booking tool, or purchase control.
- ☐ Remove unnecessary navigation, competing calls to action, intrusive pop-ups, and other distractions.
- ☐ Provide useful, original information and trust signals such as policies, contact details, qualifications, testimonials, or reviews when appropriate.
- ☐ Verify that pricing, promotions, inventory, deadlines, and eligibility details agree with the ad.
- ☐ Test the page on mobile: readable text, tappable controls, simple navigation, fast loading, and no horizontal scrolling.
- ☐ Confirm the final URL loads securely, has no broken elements, and preserves any required tracking parameters.
- ☐ Submit a test conversion and confirm that the correct confirmation state appears.

8. Measure, Review, and Publish

- ☐ Verify the Google tag and conversion action without creating duplicates; confirm that the correct action is marked Primary for the campaign's bidding goal.
- ☐ Use consistent UTM parameters or another approved naming system when campaign analytics require them.
- ☐ Review the entire path: search theme -> keyword group -> ad message -> final URL -> landing-page action.
- ☐ Resolve disapprovals, policy issues, missing assets, targeting conflicts, and warnings; then recheck spelling, budget, bidding, locations, languages, schedule, networks, negatives, and final URLs.
- ☐ Record the launch date, owner, approval, baseline metrics, and date for the first performance review.
- ☐ After launch, review search terms, negatives, conversion quality, cost, landing-page behavior, and asset performance before making major changes.
- ☐ Allow enough time and data for evaluation; avoid repeatedly resetting a learning campaign with unnecessary major edits.

FINAL LAUNCH QUESTION

• If the exact target customer saw this ad after making the intended search, would the message and landing page make the next step clear, credible, and easy?

Sources and Further Guidance

- Create a Search campaign - Google Ads Help
- Basic tips for building a keyword list - Google Ads Help
- About negative keywords - Google Ads Help
- Determine a bid strategy based on your goals - Google Ads Help
- About responsive search ads - Google Ads Help
- Optimize your ads and landing pages - Google Ads Help
- Set up your web conversions - Google Ads Help